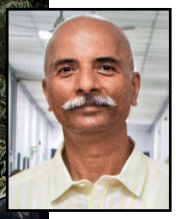
SUMIT KUMAR





WIND OF CHANGE
The Uttar Pradesh Public Service Commission office in Prayagraj, (inset) its chairman Sanjay Shrinet

UP PUBLIC SERVICE COMMISSION

TEST OF SINCERITY

By Ashish Misra

The Uttar Pradesh government has gone into overdrive to not just ensure a fair and transparent recruitment process but also rationalise the examinations conducted by the UP Public Service Commission (UPPSC). In a big relief to the aspirants, the commission has done away with the mandatory optional subject in the main paper of the Combined State/ Senior Subordinate Services Exam, popularly known as the PCS exam. Now, those clearing the preliminary exam (scheduled on May 14) will have to write only two state-centric general studies papers in the main exam (to begin on September 23).

The decision was taken in the cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on February 22. The scaling methods adopted earlier to establish homogeneity in marks among optional subjects had remained a source of discontent. A common question paper is expected to provide a level playing field to all candidates.

In another major reform, on January 3, the CM had launched the One Time Registration (OTR) system, which saves the candidates from going through the lengthy process to apply for different UPPSC exams. Now, while applying for any exam, the candidates have to just enter their unique OTR number on the commission's website and deposit the fee.

From April 1, the OTR system has been implemented for all examinations conducted by the commission. "An institutional effort was needed," says UPPSC chairman Sanjay Shrinet, "to maintain the interest of honest candidates as well as the sanctity of the examinations." More than 250,000 people have already registered on the platform developed with the help of the National Informatics Centre (NIC).

There was a time when corruption had become synonymous with the working of the commission. Embroiled in controversies, it had to cancel or postpone a number of exams. Even as the CBI was probing alleged irregularities in exams conducted between 2012 and 2017, the UPPSC examination controller was arrested for her alleged role in a paper leak case in 2019.

RATIONALISATION OF EXAMS AND TRANSPARENCY IN THE PROCESS ARE THE CORNERSTONE OF THE ONGOING UPPSC REFORMS

Given this chequered history, transparency is the cornerstone of the ongoing reforms. "The state government has ensured the sanctity of the selection process through a fair and transparent system," says CM Adityanath. "Government jobs have been provided to more than 550,000 youths in the state through this medium. The UPPSC has played an important role in this work."

The evaluation of answer sheets, for instance, has been made "foolproof". Instead of the roll number, the answer sheets carry a unique code to conceal the candidate's identity. The interview process, too, has been made "nameless and faceless". The interview board is provided only a random code, concealing the candidate's name, caste, college/ university and other details.

At the time Shrinet took charge of the UPPSC in 2021, it was facing constant criticism over the quality and accuracy of examination questions. After a review, 80 subject experts engaged by the commission were shown the door in August last year. Another source of criticism has been the delay in declaring results. Now, the calendar of examinations is being implemented strictly. In fact, the PCS-2022 results were declared on April 7, ahead of the April 15 deadline. And, in a first, well before the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC)'s civil services exam results. The efforts and their positive results are clearly showing. ■